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**Research Article on 'Future of Print Media in Digital Era'**

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### **Abstract**

The future of print media is at a pivotal juncture as it faces competition from rapidly growing digital platforms. Newspapers, one of the oldest forms of mass communication, have evolved from ancient Roman bulletins to the modern global print industry. The digital era has brought significant challenges to traditional print media, with the emergence of smartphones, social media, and 24-hour news cycles fundamentally changing how news is accessed and consumed. Despite the perpetual decline in print readership, especially in the U.S. and Europe, print media remains resilient in certain regions such as Japan and India. This paper reviews the historical trajectory of print media, examines the transition to digital platforms, and explores the twin crises faced by the industry—declining circulation and revenue. It interprets the current circumstances that print media is going through and predicts its future with a comparative analysis of print media's relevance in North America, Asia, and Africa and provides insights into the ongoing transformation and adaptation strategies employed by the print industry.

### **‘Future of Print Media in Digital Era’**

Newspapers are the oldest tools of mass communication widely used for spreading news. This tradition traces back to 59 BCE in Rome where hand-written bulletins conveyed official news, including political and social updates known as "Acta Diurna" (meaning "Daily Acts"). From the BCE to the modern era mass communication of societies evolved when the invention of the printing press by Johannes Gutenberg in the mid-15th century revolutionized mass communication, enabling the wider distribution of news. The first printed newspaper, "Relation," was published in 1605 in Strasbourg, which significantly increased the reach of news and information across Europe.

The Printing press intervention spread all over Europe and America. Newspapers became the source of credible news and mass communication. In the 17<sup>th</sup> century, Newspapers spread to the UK and even in American colonies as a form of communication tool, The London Gazette which was first published in 1665 was considered one of the oldest continuously published newspapers, while The Boston News-Letter of 1704 was the first regularly published newspaper in the American colonies.

By the 19<sup>th</sup> century, new forms of communication such as Photography and the Telegraph had emerged. Later, Radio and film became prominent. The mid-20<sup>th</sup> century saw the revolutionary arrival of Television, with channels like BBC, NBC, and CBS. Television brought with it the concept of live coverage of events, such as political debates, the moon landing in 1969, and breaking news, fundamentally changing the way news was experienced and consumed.

The Internet and digital media originally originated for military and academic use. However, in the 1990s, the Internet became accessible to the general public, resulting in a significant transformation in communication. This era saw the emergence of email, online forums, and websites, enabling instantaneous, global information exchange. Additionally, online news platforms started to appear, and in 1995, CNN launched the first 24-hour news website, further revolutionizing the way people accessed and consumed news.

The emergence of social media marked a new era in communication, with the launch of groundbreaking platforms like Facebook in 2004, Twitter in 2006, and YouTube in 2005. This transformation revolutionized the dissemination of news, introducing user-generated content and enabling the rapid spread of viral news stories. Moreover, it facilitated direct interaction between public figures and the general public. As a result, social media quickly became a primary source of news and information for younger generations, often surpassing traditional media outlets in terms of speed and reach.

- **The transition from Print to Digital Media**

The shift from traditional print and offline communication to online platforms was propelled by the introduction of smartphones such as the iPhone in 2007. This technological leap led to mobile devices becoming the primary means of accessing news. With the widespread availability of mobile internet, along with the introduction of apps, news alerts, and live streaming, people gained the ability to instantly access information from any location around the globe. In response to these changes, traditional media sources adapted to the digital era by launching online versions of their newspapers, radio programs, and television broadcasts. Furthermore, the rise of streaming services like Netflix and YouTube revolutionized entertainment and news consumption by offering on-demand content.

Since 2010 with the emergence of apps like Instagram, the information industry has been on every hand. The reading and circulation of newspapers/ Tabloids / Pamphlets started to decrease in the first world countries where all of the social media platforms were in their rising prominence.

The integration of online platforms, social media, and streaming services has given rise to an uninterrupted stream of news, commonly known as the 24-hour news cycle. Information is constantly being updated and is accessible at any hour of the day. The emergence of smartphones and social media has empowered regular people to share news, often broadcasting real-time occurrences before traditional news organizations. Nowadays, news platforms and social media utilize AI algorithms to

personalize content based on individual preferences, sparking discussions about information bubbles and partiality in mass communication.

In today's world, mass communication has become extremely decentralized and interactive.

Information now spreads through a complex network of digital platforms, traditional media, and personal networks. The speed and scale of communication have fundamentally transformed how societies receive, interpret, and respond to information.

- **Twin Crises**

The term 'Twin Crises' was originally used in academic research studies to analyze the future of print media. The Twin Crises, a concept in economics, occur when a banking crisis and a currency crisis happen simultaneously. A banking crisis is characterized by widespread bank failures or bank runs, while a currency crisis involves a sharp devaluation of a country's currency. When these two crises occur together, they can amplify each other's negative effects, leading to a spiral of economic instability. For example, a currency crisis can lead to bank failures as the value of assets held by banks declines, while bank failures can exacerbate the currency crisis by eroding confidence in the financial system. This interplay between the two crises can have far-reaching implications for economic stability and growth.

Over the years, the circulation of printed publications has been steadily decreasing. However, a significant shift in consumer behavior was observed as highlighted in the 'World Press Trends Report' by the 'World Association of Newspapers' in 2010. This shift was primarily driven by the increasing use of the Internet. The availability of vast amounts of information online, along with the ability to personalize news consumption based on individual interests, led to a rapid migration of audiences to online platforms for their news. Furthermore, the ability to receive news updates multiple times a day, as opposed to just once in the morning, significantly contributed to this trend. The online landscape offers an array of sources, from opinion blogs to online-only newspapers like The Daily, which was specifically tailored for users of Apple's iPad.

The proliferation of news websites and apps has been exponential. The concept of accessing news for free on the Internet became increasingly attractive during the financial crisis of 2007-2008, a time when newspaper circulation in the United States plummeted by 30 percent, as reported by World Press Trends.

Over time, shifts in consumer behavior have resulted in a significant movement of advertising budgets from traditional print media to the online sphere. However, even with this transition, the revenue generated from online advertising remains considerably less than that from print advertising sales. Scott Karp, co-founder and CEO of a content distribution platform, has termed this situation the "10 percent problem." For instance, in the case of The New York Times, the print circulation reaches only about 10 percent of the total audience, while online advertising revenue also hovers around 10 percent. This creates an almost perfect inverse relationship between the expected and actual revenues from online and print advertising, given their respective readerships. These intertwined developments, along with their ramifications, have given rise to what is now known as the "twin crises."

News organizations are grappling with the significant challenge of coping with decreases in traditional print circulation and advertising income at present. This struggle is compounded by the presence of abundant free online content, which they must compete with despite not being able to generate revenue from it.

The simultaneous challenges faced by the industry, known as the "twin crises," have had significant implications. Firstly, there has been a persistent trend of job cuts, with seasoned journalists, who command higher salaries, becoming increasingly expendable. Secondly, there has been a noticeable decrease in the standard of journalism, coupled with the emergence of more sensational and populist publications. It is worth noting that the growing popularity of tabloids has been attributed to the broadening of readership, including new audiences with lower incomes.

In recent times, news organizations have been adopting more competitive and high-quality strategies. For example, some have introduced paywalls and engaged in further ownership

consolidation, with large industry players acquiring smaller ones. Despite the global economic downturn, newspaper circulation worldwide experienced only a minor decline. This trend was particularly evident in countries such as Germany in Europe.

### **Methodology**

To comprehend the relevance and prevalence of print media and make predictions about its future, a comprehensive literature review was conducted.

The review encompassed an analysis of 10 research papers and articles from renowned journals. Furthermore, the study involved researching surveys and interviews carried out globally, leading to the categorization of countries by continent and the subsequent presentation of data based on this categorization.

### **Print relevance in North America with the viewpoint of the USA**

The print media industry in the United States is facing challenges, particularly in the print news sector where circulation is on the decline and advertising revenues remain stagnant.

The Editor and Publisher Yearbook data revealed a decline in industry daily circulation during the six months from April to September 2006. Upon closer examination, it became evident that the majority of this decrease could be attributed to the diminishing popularity and eventual discontinuation of evening editions. The circulation of these editions plummeted from 21 million in 1990 to less than 7 million in 2006. In contrast, morning daily circulation exhibited a consistent increase, rising from 41.31 million in 1990 to 46.93 million in 2003. However, this growth stalled in 2003, and by the end of 2006, the circulation of morning papers had declined by 3.17 percent (Editor and Publisher Yearbook, 2007).

The print media industry is currently witnessing a significant shift, particularly when comparing the trends in national daily newspapers to those of regional newspapers. There has been a notable increase in circulation for regional papers, suggesting a potential decrease in readership for national dailies. This shift can be attributed to the fact that readers are showing a growing interest in local news, politics, and sports, areas where regional dailies are better positioned to provide comprehensive coverage compared to larger national newspapers.



Moreover, it's worth noting that the total number of morning papers in the U.S. has continued to grow steadily. By the end of 2006, the number of morning edition news dailies had increased to 833, displaying an upward trend from the 817 recorded in 2005. On the other hand, the number of Sunday papers has maintained a relatively stable count since 1997 when it first surpassed 900. Minor fluctuations within a narrow range have characterized the trend since then. The number of evening papers continues to decline at a fast pace, from 1,084 in 1990 to 614 in 2006, which signifies their bleak future in the present circumstances (Newspaper Association of America, 2007).

A significant reason cited by 23% of the respondents is a lack of time. This trend began in the late sixties and intensified with the advent of the World Wide Web. Among people who still read the print news, almost half said the biggest attraction was local news, followed by culture and arts (Online Papers Modestly Boost Newspaper Readership, 2006).

It is generally believed that the decline in circulation is a result of declining interest in reading, especially among the young. Some industry experts believe that the decline is due to a multitude of reasons. The most important, it seems, is the migration of print readers, especially the young, to online sources. Second in importance is the perception that the present generation of young adults comprises a lot more people who have little or no interest in news or reading in general.

There is evidence to suggest that newspaper readership among younger demographics has declined significantly since 1992. According to a survey conducted by the Pew Research Centre for the People and the Press, there has been a 20% decrease in the number of individuals who report reading newspapers regularly. The data from the survey also indicates that changes in lifestyle patterns since the early nineties have played a significant role in this shift.

### **Prevalence of Print in Asia through Japan and India**

Out of the top 100 best-selling daily newspapers worldwide, 60 are published in Japan, India, and China. The five countries with the highest daily newspaper circulation are China (98.70 million), India (88.90 million), Japan (69.10 million), the United States (52.30 million), and Germany (21.10 million) according to World Press Trends (2007).

Japan has one of the highest rates of literacy in the world and reading habits have been deeply ingrained. 122 daily newspapers are printing about 69 million copies every day. By comparison, the number of copies published in the United States is 52 million, and in China 98 million. The Yomiuri, which prints over 10 million copies of the morning edition, started publishing in 1874 and is ranked as the world's biggest newspaper. The Asahi, with a daily circulation of over 8 million copies, is Japan's second-largest newspaper.

In Japan, major national dailies like Yomiuri are connected with television broadcast channels such as Nippon TV Network (Channel 4) and Asahi Shimbun with Channel 10. Other connections include Nihon Keizai Shimbun with TV Tokyo (Channel 12), Mainichi with TBS Channel 6, and Sankei with Fuji TV (Channel 8). Additionally, The Yomiuri launched its Internet news service in June 1995 in response to the increasing popularity of the Internet and the rapid launch of websites among U.S. media.

The Yomiuri Online stabilized in early 2005 and reported 6.6 million unique hits. The website posts about 200 stories daily, with 80% of the content from its morning and evening editions. It updates around the clock. Nikkei is the only newspaper in Japan with a profitable web-based presence, adopting a subscription-based revenue model similar to the Wall Street Journal.

The 2005 circulation figures from Nihon Shimbun Kyokai (The Japan Newspaper Publishers & Editors Association) show that the total circulation of newspapers published in Japan slightly decreased from 52.85 million in 1995 to 52.56 million in 2005. During the same period, the number of subscriptions per household declined steadily from 1.19 to 1.04, representing a 15 percent drop. However, the circulation of morning papers increased from 31.64 million in 1995 to 33.92 million in 2005, marking a 7.21 percent rise. On the other hand, the circulation of evening papers declined by 24.24 percent, from 2.01 million to 1.52 million. This decrease in evening edition readership is believed to be due to changing lifestyles and a lack of free time. The combined circulation of both morning and evening editions dropped by 10.84 percent.

The newspaper industry has seen a decline in advertising revenue, possibly due to the reduced circulation of evening papers. However, sales revenue has been consistent. In Japan, major media establishments have integrated radio, television, and online platforms more extensively than in other countries.

### **India in News**

In 2006, India's media and entertainment industry experienced a 20% increase in revenues. It is projected that these revenues will more than double to \$22.5 billion by 2011, largely due to foreign interest and investment in the industry. This information is derived from a recent study conducted by Price Waterhouse Coopers (PWC) on behalf of the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI). The study indicates that the media industry's growth rate will surpass that of the overall economy annually for the next five years.

The country's strong economic growth, coupled with increasing incomes and consumer spending, will lead to a surge in the media industry. This growth will be driven by expanded information delivery options through mobile phones and the Internet, benefiting all segments of the industry, from radio to newspapers.

The studies suggest that the media industry will be driven by increasing demand, technological advancements such as internet and mobile TV viewing, government initiatives to promote investment, and private media firms' investments. Over the last three years, the press medium (both newspapers and magazines) has expanded its reach from 179 million to 200 million. The proportion of the population aged 15 years and above has also increased from 26.4 percent to 27.4 percent (PWC Report, 2007).

The most recent report by the National Readership Survey indicates that the literacy rate has seen a significant increase, rising from 62.5 percent to 70.6 percent. This increase has been particularly notable in rural areas, where the literacy rate has jumped by nearly ten percentage points, from 55.6 percent to 64.6 percent. In urban India, the rise has been more modest, but still significant, with the literacy rate increasing from 79.3 percent to 84.5 percent. It is expected that this increase in

literacy rates will have a positive impact on the market for print media, as more people gain the ability to read. The growth in print media has been largely driven by daily publications, with their readership increasing from 23 percent to 24 percent.

There is considerable potential for growth in print media in India, particularly in regional publications in local languages. Dainik Jagran, India's largest vernacular newspaper, has seen significant growth, doubling its circulation to over 2.5 million in the last 5 years. Foreign investment in Indian media companies is capped at 26%, with no provision for management control by foreigners.

The Indian print media industry has attracted \$90 million in foreign investment over the past three years. It stands out globally with its strong growth in newspaper circulation and revenues. According to World Press Trends, published by the World Association of Newspapers, the number of Indian newspapers increased by 22.8 percent from 2001 to 2005, reaching 1,834 in total.

Timothy Balding, CEO of the World Association of Newspapers, emphasized the robust performance of the industry despite increasing competition from other media, stating that newspapers are thriving. The data indicates a 33 percent increase in Indian dailies' circulation, from 59 million in 2001 to over 78 million in 2005. Furthermore, newspapers in India earned more advertising revenues than cinema, magazines, radio, and the Internet combined.

### **Prevalence of Print in Africa through the Viewpoint of Kenya**

To keep up with the trend, most newspaper companies, national and international own media outlets. For example, the Washington Post Company owns Newsweek magazines and the Chicago Tribune company owns several broadcast stations.

In Kenya, newspaper companies such as the Nation Media Group own radio stations and television channels like NTV and QTV. The NMG has also expanded its operations to include electronic money transfers under the name NationHela to grow its economic reach. The Standard also owns radio stations and a television channel, KTN. These newspapers are mainly controlled by

corporate executives rather than independent publishers, and these executives have other business interests.

In contemporary Kenya, the majority of newspapers heavily depend on major news agencies such as the Associated Press, Reuters, the New York Times News Service, and the Washington Post-Los Angeles Times New Service for comprehensive coverage of international and national news.

In 1995, Thompson reported that United Press International, which used to be the main competitor to the Associated Press, faced financial difficulties in the 1980s and early 1990s and had to reduce its news-gathering staff. Most major newspapers have also added opinion pages to present diverse views. Currently, leading print media outlets are rapidly adjusting to compete with online journalism.

For instance, the Nation Media Group (NMG) and the Standard Group, which publish the leading newspapers in Kenya, have embraced online and digital formats for their newspapers. They have also started using multimedia channels to provide readers with image galleries along with video and audio content for their online versions. Additionally, they have incorporated social media networking sites to engage with their readers. Despite the challenges posed by the new media, most companies in Kenya have diversified into other businesses or combined media ventures. It's rare to find a newspaper in Kenya that solely focuses on print publications without venturing into other revenue-generating enterprises. In contrast to other countries where newspapers are declining, the number of newspapers in Kenya has grown from four main ones in 2002 to around 10 in 2012. Some of these newspapers are exclusively online publications, while others have both print and online editions.

Secondly, nearly all newspapers have introduced online editions to keep pace with evolving technology. These internet and online editions can be accessed on internet-enabled computers, and more recently, on mobile phones. To maintain the authenticity of printed newspapers, online editions have limited content, with most advertisements and entertainment reserved for the printed versions.

The dwindling readership and limited time for reading printed newspapers is a concern in Kenya. Many consumers are now drawn to bite-sized content like chat codes that are quick to digest. While some believe that newspapers are not going anywhere, the key question is whether they will continue in printed form or transition to digital. The future of newspapers will ultimately be shaped by the preferences of the readers, as both formats have their advantages and drawbacks.

## Discussion

The transformation of print media becomes apparent when we look at the history of traditional newspapers. Starting from the very first printed newspaper "Relation" in 1605, printed media reigned supreme in the realm of communication for centuries. Evening editions in the U.S. stood out as a prominent feature of this era. However, everything changed with the emergence of digital platforms and smartphones. The launch of the iPhone in 2007 marked a significant shift in the way people consumed news. The print media industry in the United States has experienced a continuous decline in circulation over the years, and the shift to online platforms has not been able to offset the loss in advertising revenues. Particularly, younger audiences are leaning more toward digital news sources due to the immediacy and personalized content they offer. This shift has led to what some refer to as the "twin crises" of dwindling readership and revenue in print media, resulting in job layoffs and a decrease in the overall quality of journalism. Notably, there has been a rise in sensationalist publications as a consequence of these challenges. In countries such as Japan and India, the print media industry continues to show resilience. Daily newspapers like "Yomiuri" and "Asahi" in Japan have managed to maintain significant circulation by adapting to integrated multimedia platforms to remain competitive. Similarly, India's print industry is experiencing growth due to rising literacy rates, an expanding economy, and a preference for regional language newspapers. In Africa, the nation of Kenya is experiencing a gradual yet consistent shift towards digital media, although traditional print publications continue to play a significant role, particularly in the dissemination of local news. Kenyan newspapers have also expanded into other forms of media, such as television and radio, to ensure their financial sustainability.

In an era of increasing digitalization, countries worldwide are witnessing a shift towards digital media consumption, while the print industry is undergoing restructuring to align with accessibility standards and sustain its presence. In developing nations with diverse regional languages, print media continues to be a significant content consumption channel.

## **Conclusion**

The future of print media is increasingly connected to digital platforms as the industry adjusts to changes in consumer behavior, technological advancements, and economic pressures. While print circulation and revenue have significantly decreased in regions like the U.S. and Europe, other areas such as Japan, India, and parts of Africa still have a strong print industry. The challenges faced by print media, such as reduced circulation and advertising revenue, are leading to innovations. Newspapers are implementing strategies like paywalls, online platforms, and multimedia integration to address these "twin crises."

In conclusion, the importance of print media differs by region, but the overall trend shows a global movement towards digital media. However, the continued use of print media in certain markets, particularly in Asia, suggests that while it may no longer be the dominant form of media, it still holds significant value in various contexts. The future of print media will depend on its ability to adapt to the digital era while preserving its credibility and unique strengths.



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